

Common Characteristics of Adult Dyslexia

Workplace and Career Patterns

Adults with dyslexia often gravitate toward positions that allow them to work around their challenges while leveraging their strengths:

- **Job Selection:** Choose careers that minimize exposure to difficult areas or allow them to mask their struggles
- **Concealment:** Hide reading, writing, or organizational difficulties from colleagues, friends, and sometimes family members
- **Meeting Frustrations:** Become impatient during planning meetings and sequential tasks, often already knowing the solution intuitively
- **Administrative Avoidance:** May decline promotions that involve increased paperwork or administrative responsibilities
- **Multitasking Preference:** Struggle with sustained focus on single tasks but excel at managing multiple projects simultaneously
- **Testing Barriers:** Face challenges with standardized tests that can limit career advancement opportunities

Career Strengths: Thrive in visual-spatial and hands-on fields such as entrepreneurship, engineering, skilled trades, creative arts, law enforcement, athletics, and executive leadership roles.

Work Patterns: Display either exceptional achievement or underperformance relative to potential, consistently demonstrating strong work ethic regardless of outcome.

Learning and Cognitive Style

- **Learning Preferences:** Excel with hands-on experience, demonstrations, visual aids, and experimentation rather than traditional instruction
- **Thinking Patterns:** Either highly creative "out-of-the-box" thinkers or operate within very structured, self-imposed rules
- **Perfectionism:** May overreact to mistakes and set extremely high standards for themselves
- **Intuitive Abilities:** Often possess strong "street smarts" and excel at reading people and situations
- **Environmental Sensitivity:** Easily distracted by background noise and environmental factors

Reading and Language Challenges

Reading Difficulties:

- Struggle with unfamiliar fonts and formatting
- Avoid reading aloud and public speaking when possible

- Experience fluctuating comprehension depending on subject matter
- Frequently need to re-read sentences for understanding
- Fatigue quickly during reading tasks
- Feel more confident reading silently than aloud

Writing and Spelling:

- Rely heavily on spell-check and grammar tools
- Use compensatory strategies for common spelling challenges (homophones like their/there/they're)
- Exhibit inconsistent or phonetic spelling patterns
- Often write in all capitals or mix capital letters within words
- Frequently abbreviate words
- May have poor handwriting that masks spelling errors
- Depend on others for written correspondence

Verbal Communication:

- Mispronounce or misuse words without awareness
- Experience difficulty retrieving words, especially under stress
- May pause frequently or leave sentences incomplete when speaking in groups
- Struggle with verbal instructions and directions

Memory and Information Processing

Memory Strengths and Challenges:

- Excellent recall for experiential events but may forget others completely
- Strong facial recognition but difficulty remembering names without memory tricks
- May confuse details from past conversations or be perceived as "not listening"
- Struggle with sequential memory and following multi-step verbal instructions

Time and Spatial Awareness:

- Difficulty with left/right orientation and cardinal directions
- Either get lost easily or never forget a location once visited
- Struggle with map reading and navigation
- Experience anxiety when driving in unfamiliar areas
- Poor time estimation skills, leading to frequent lateness or obsessive punctuality

Mathematical and Logical Thinking

- May understand complex mathematical concepts but struggle to demonstrate knowledge on paper
- Either excel at mathematics or rely on basic counting methods and calculators
- Difficulty with practical math applications like making change
- Strong problem-solving abilities that don't always translate to traditional assessments

Behavioral and Emotional Patterns

Stress Responses:

- Easily frustrated, especially in challenging or unfamiliar situations
- Become overwhelmed when outside their comfort zone
- Avoid new tasks or situations that might expose their difficulties
- Experience increased symptoms under stress, fatigue, or time pressure

Self-Perception:

- Often struggle with low self-esteem related to academic or professional challenges
- Self-conscious in group settings, particularly when required to speak
- May have experienced significant school-related struggles that continue to impact confidence

Organization and Routine:

- Tend toward extremes: either highly disorganized or compulsively orderly
- May "zone out" without realizing it
- Benefit from structured environments but struggle with rigid sequential processes

Additional Characteristics

- **Technology Engagement:** Often enjoy video games and interactive media
- **Physical Traits:** May have balance issues or, conversely, be highly athletic
- **Intergenerational Patterns:** Frequently have dyslexic children and experience anxiety when helping with homework or reading to their children
- **Sensory Processing:** May be sensitive to emotions and energy of others

Assessment Consideration

If you, your spouse, or an employee displays at least 10 of these characteristics, an initial consultation may be appropriate to determine if specialized support programs would be beneficial.